

Martenn Vell is, by every objective measure, a gecko.

He is three and a half feet tall, covered in chartreuse scales, with a fat soft tail, gold-ringed eyes he occasionally licks when he thinks no one is watching, and toes that grip stone. He speaks the common tongue with a Balenthass port accent, and Draconic with what scholars would recognize as a flawless Zehiri inflection.

He will tell you he is part dragon. On his mother's side. This is, if you allow adoption — and the Zehiri, he will remind you, do — technically true.

He was born in Balenthass, in a portside quarter, and grew up around one of the few places in the world where trade still feels as robust as it did in the days of the empire. Martenn's gift was that he could sell a thing that did not exist to a person who did not need it and leave them feeling they had won. He never sold goods. Goods can be counted. He sold the dream.

As more and more people found their innate magic—hedge witches outside of the city, clerics healing people in their temples—he realized that people would believe anything. He didn't have any innate magic. At least not yet. But he knew that didn't matter if he could sell the idea of magic. Martenn founded the Worshipful Company of Practical Mysteries. He was its registrar, its treasurer, and its entire membership committee. He sold certificates of standing with a wax seal he designed himself. He sold introductions, testimonials, and a service he called *magical reputation management*, which means as little as it sounds like.

And here is the thing that makes Martenn Vell a tragedy rather than a joke: he was *good* at it. The bone-mender he represented tripled her practice. The dream-reader got a standing arrangement with a shipping consortium. For about four years, Martenn Vell made modest magical professionals into comfortable ones and took his cut, and if he had been content to just be good, he would still be tall.

Mother Osk kept a narrow shop three streets up from the harbor, and she was the real thing — curses that held, contracts that bound, problems that stopped being problems and were never spoken of again. She had no sign. She had never needed one. Martenn walked into her shop uninvited and pitched her the grandest campaign of his career, the one he had been saving: **the Full Circle Executive Experience**. No one in Balenthass wouldn't know her, he promised. She paid. Witches pay in coin like anyone; the coin was substantial.

What Mother Osk received, over the following year, was: half a mural on the harbor wall, defaced within the month. A song, commissioned from a bard who took the fee and wrote one verse. Forty printed handbills, and Martenn waving and spinning a billboard in the town square. When she came to complain, he told her that viral campaigns take time, and that she was thinking too small.

There was a gecko on the wall of his office. Mother Osk looked at him and said “you failed to make me big. I will not fail to make you small.” She fused him and the gecko, and walked out of

his office as the now 3.5 foot tall man tried to disentangle himself from clothes that were now big enough to hold three of him.

She did not, however, take away his mouth or his ability to sell a story. People look at him and see a gecko. He looked in a mirror and thought “who’s that handsome half dragon.” He sailed to the Zahiri coast, where old legend said the dragons still lived. He hid, lied, and snuck until he found himself at the foot of the hoard of an amber dragon who had just given birth to wyrmlings. She looked at Martenn, small, scaled, loud, furious — and concluded, with the generous eye of a new mother, that he was the runt.

Of course, deep down, she knew. He had no wings. He could not breathe fire. But he loved gold as much as a dragon should. She fed him from her own fire. Literally: the magic of that nursery soaked into the curse the way heat soaks into stone, and the curse, being well-made, adapted. He learned Draconic. He learned that fire will come to your hand if you believe it enough.

He was there five years. The end came the way these ends come: the clutch fledged, and wings opened one by one down the ridge like sails, and Martenn stood at the edge of the hoard-cave and asked, in front of everyone, when his would be coming in, knowing full well that they wouldn’t. When the other hatchlings had flown, his adopted mother leaned down and said:

“Smallest of my treasures, she said. Go and be loud. Little hands go where wings cannot. When it matters, hold this, and ask.”

She gave him one of her scales, and helped him to graft it to his own. She became his patron—an old magical bond that the elven empire suppressed. Through her, he can perform magic. This also means that, to keep that magic, he has to call his “mother” every day or she will be very cross with him indeed and the next time he needs to cast a spell could find himself wanting. He pretends to be bitter about this, but secretly enjoys his roll as mama’s boy, the runt of the litter and her favorite.

He moved back to balenthass—not to the capital city. He still had his same voice when he spoke, and he had burned too many bridges there. He settled in Larracos, a port slightly closer to Valdrek, and got back to what he was good at. Selling dreams. But now he could use his own magic, or, as she might remind him, his mothers, to make his exploits even more profitable.